

ESSENTIAL

Student Visa Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - points-based system, CAS, funds, work rights, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the Student visa is - and isn't

The Student visa is the main route for studying in the UK for longer than 6 months at a licensed Student sponsor - typically a university, but also some colleges. It's assessed under Appendix Student of the Immigration Rules on a points-based system: 70 points total, made up of 50 points for a valid CAS and course, 10 for English language, and 10 for the financial requirement. It does not cover short courses under 6 months (a Short-term Study visitor route or the Visitor route may apply instead), and applicants under 18 fall under the related Child Student route with some different conditions.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Get an offer and CAS	Accept an unconditional offer from a licensed Student sponsor and (usually) pay any required deposit; your sponsor then issues your CAS.
2. Apply online	Complete the application at gov.uk using your CAS reference number.
3. Pay fee and IHS	Pay the visa fee and the Immigration Health Surcharge, calculated for your full course length and paid upfront.
4. Prove your identity	Enrol biometrics at a Visa Application Centre, or use the ID Check app if eligible.
5. Submit documents	Upload financial evidence and, if required, your ATAS certificate and TB test certificate - see the Document Checklist.
6. Decision	Standard processing is commonly around 3 weeks outside the UK; priority services (extra fee) can be faster. Some applicants are asked to attend a credibility ("Genuine Student") interview.
7. Get your visa	If approved, you'll typically get a digital eVisa - check gov.uk for the current process for your application type.

The points-based system, briefly

- 50 points: a valid CAS from a licensed Student sponsor, for a course at the required academic level, that isn't already fully funded through a route that doesn't need a Student visa
- 10 points: English language ability at the required level - usually satisfied through the course itself, an approved test, nationality, or prior qualifications
- 10 points: the financial (maintenance) requirement - see the Financial Requirements Overview

Work rights while studying

Unlike the Visitor route (no work at all) and different from many other countries' student visas, Student visa holders at degree level or above studying with a higher education provider can generally work part-time - commonly up to 20 hours per week during term time, and full-time during vacations. Courses below degree level are more restricted, commonly to 10 hours per week. Self-employment, filling a permanent full-time vacancy, and working as a professional sportsperson or entertainer are not permitted on any Student visa. Your specific conditions are stated on your visa/eVisa - always check your own rather than assuming a general figure applies.

Dependants

Bringing dependants (a partner or children) on a Student visa is now restricted to a narrower set of circumstances than in the past - broadly, postgraduate research students (PhD and other research programmes) and those on a government-sponsored course of a required minimum length. Most taught postgraduate and undergraduate students cannot bring dependants under current rules. Check your specific eligibility on gov.uk before assuming either way, since this has changed in recent years and may change again.

Frequently asked questions

Do I need ATAS?

Only if your specific course and nationality are on the ATAS list - mainly certain postgraduate research courses in STEM, engineering, and security-relevant fields. Ask your sponsor's international office directly; it isn't required for most taught courses.

What happens after I finish my course?

Many graduates become eligible to switch to the Graduate visa, a separate post-study work route (commonly 2 years, or 3 years for a PhD) that doesn't require a job offer or sponsor. That switch, and its own requirements, are outside the scope of this guide.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for Administrative Review eligibility and how to approach reapplying.